of boundaries through point, but he can also get out in that zone; areas of strength can always be areas of weakness, so we could nick him off a wide ball; don't give him too many short balls, because he plays them well and they can help to get his feet going.

Batsman B, a world-class Sri Lankan batsman: in Tests, pepper him with short balls until his feet are nowhere and, as soon as he looks disturbed, nick him outside off; in ODIs, he's a brilliant player of spin, so starve him of spinners and bring mid-on into the circle and invite him to hit over the top; that's his weakness.

Batsman C, a high-quality Australian batsman: bowl straight at all times, giving him no width and no room; put long-off and long-on right back on the boundary because he can score heavily in that area but he can also get out. Give him a few bouncers as well, because he thinks he's good with the short ball, but he isn't.

So preparations continued, until detailed plans for every opposing player had been developed, discussed and debated with coaches and players, and then committed to memory; and, even then, the captain's work is just starting because he needs to be 100% alert and aware whenever his squad is together, travelling or training, eating or meeting, warming up, batting or fielding, constantly asking himself: 'Am I doing the right thing? Do I need to give that guy a boost? Do I need to have a firm word with that player? What will I say at the next meeting? Am I having an impact? Are the selectors thinking the same way? Are the coaches happy with that option? What is the alternative if that doesn't work?'

It never stops.